

Richard Wiseman's *The Luck Factor*: Research and Main Findings

Cover of the book *The Luck Factor* by Richard Wiseman (English edition).

Overview and Nature of Luck According to Wiseman

Richard J. Wiseman, a British psychologist, carried out a scientific study spanning nearly a decade on the nature of luck. He recruited hundreds of volunteers (400 men and women aged 18 to 84, coming from diverse backgrounds) who considered themselves exceptionally lucky or unlucky. Over the course of 8–10 years, Wiseman employed in-depth interviews, personal diaries, psychometric questionnaires, intelligence tests, and laboratory experiments to analyze the psychological differences between people with “good” or “bad” luck. His findings demystify luck as a merely random phenomenon: he discovered that what we call “luck” is often the result of our attitudes and behaviors. In Wiseman's words, “luck is not something paranormal; it is something we create with our thoughts and behaviors.” In essence, each individual contributes largely to forging their own luck through certain psychological and social habits.

Wiseman observed that people who define themselves as “lucky” tend to behave very differently from those who consider themselves “unlucky.” For example, lucky people tend to be more extroverted, relaxed, and open to the new, while unlucky people tend to be more anxious or tense. These differences influence how they face life: lucky people generate more favorable “coincidences” because they seek out and take advantage of opportunities, trust their intuition, expect positive results, and know how to cope with setbacks; conversely, the anxiety and negative vision of the unlucky often block opportunities or make them overlook fortuitous events. In sum, Wiseman proposes a “psychological” view of luck: in many cases, “we make our own luck” by adopting certain mental and behavioral patterns. Below is a summary of the main findings and theories exposed in his book *The Luck Factor*, including his Four Principles of Luck, the key experiments they are based on, practical applications, and some criticisms that arose after its publication.

Wiseman's Four Principles of Luck

After analyzing the life stories and characteristics of people with much or little fortune, Wiseman concluded that lucky people apply (consciously or not) four basic principles that create good fortune in their lives. These four principles—derived from thought patterns and observable habits—are the following:

1. Maximize Fortuitous Opportunities The First Principle maintains that lucky people maximize the opportunities that arise in their lives. In practice, “lucky” people are very skilled at creating, noticing, and taking advantage of chance opportunities that present themselves. How do they achieve this? Wiseman identified several typical behaviors: they tend to know and relate to many people (expanding their “luck network”), adopt a relaxed attitude in day-to-day life, and remain open to new experiences. These behaviors increase the probability of favorable encounters or coincidences. For example, someone extroverted who frequently converses with

strangers multiplies the possibilities of stumbling upon valuable information or key people (job offers, partners, friendships, etc.), while someone withdrawn or routine-bound might miss those opportunities. Wiseman points out that lucky people “do not stay paralyzed analyzing” all options; on the contrary, they “try things” more frequently, are willing to take small risks, and learn from experience. In contrast, people with bad luck often suffer from “paralysis by analysis,” that is, they doubt and reflect too much before acting, and when they decide, the opportune moment has passed.

A famous experiment by Wiseman illustrates this principle. He asked lucky and unlucky volunteers to count how many photographs were in a newspaper. Unknown to them, on the second page of the newspaper, there was an advertisement with a huge headline that said: “Stop counting. There are 43 photos in this newspaper!” Surprisingly, the majority of the “unlucky” participants did not notice the message and continued counting laboriously, taking a couple of minutes on the task; in contrast, many of the “lucky” ones immediately saw the headline (written in letters 5 cm high) and solved the exercise in a matter of seconds. There was even another advertisement further on that offered a £150 prize for reading it, but again many unlucky people passed it by. The conclusion? Unlucky people often miss evident opportunities because they are too focused on a specific goal or obligation (such as “I must count every photo”), while lucky people maintain a more relaxed and open attitude, which allows them to notice the unexpected. In psychological terms, anxiety and tension reduce peripheral attention (inattention blindness); therefore, being relaxed and receptive increases the probability of perceiving “strokes of luck” in the environment. Wiseman summarized this principle by saying that lucky people “see what is there (real opportunities) rather than limiting themselves to looking for what they want.” His practical advice is to cultivate sociability, curiosity, and vary the routine: the more doors we knock on, the more opportunities may appear.

2. Follow Intuition and Hunches The Second Principle observed is that lucky people listen to their hunches and intuitions when making important decisions. Wiseman discovered that “lucky” people trust their inner voice much more than “unlucky” people, and that this guidance often leads them on a good path. In his surveys, almost 90% of lucky people claimed to trust their intuition in matters of personal relationships, and nearly 80% said that intuition played a vital role in career decisions; in both cases, these percentages were approximately 20% higher than among unlucky people. Likewise, lucky people tend to take concrete actions to stimulate their intuition: for example, they allow themselves moments of mental tranquility, meditation, or reflection before deciding, or pay attention to subtle signals that others would ignore. Wiseman explains that intuition is not magic, but “a large reservoir of knowledge based on patterns that our brain has accumulated.” Hunches are usually the way the subconscious mind alerts us to something important. Lucky people listen to those alerts and at least consider them (“if I have a feeling, I stop to evaluate it,” said one participant), while unlucky people tend to ignore their instincts (“since I don’t know where that feeling comes from, I discard it”), generally due to anxiety or excessive rationalization.

Wiseman demonstrates the importance of intuition with real cases of his “lucky” volunteers, who sometimes avoided catastrophes or achieved successes by following an inexplicable hunch. For example, he documented stories of people who canceled a trip at the last moment due to a bad

feeling and it turned out to be a fortunate decision. Beyond anecdotes, Wiseman incorporated into his “luck school” exercises to develop intuition, such as practicing meditation and “clearing the mind” regularly, or creative techniques to listen to the subconscious before making decisions (e.g., visualizing consulting an imaginary sage about a problem). The central message is that hunches can anticipate opportunities or dangers that logic does not detect, so learning to recognize and take advantage of those sensations improves luck. In Wiseman’s words: “you don’t always have to obey every impulse, but you could be missing out on a great source of knowledge accumulated over the years.”

3. Maintain Positive Expectations and Optimism The Third Principle identified is that lucky people expect good fortune to accompany them in the future. This optimism or positive expectation acts as a self-fulfilling prophecy: the positive beliefs of lucky people influence their perseverance and how they relate to others, increasing the probabilities of real success. Wiseman observed that those who consider themselves lucky tend to trust that they will achieve their goals, which leads them to try again and again until they achieve them, instead of giving up after a failure. This optimistic trait provides them with more “grit” or tenacity: if they believe something will turn out well, they persist more and take advantage of any opportunity to achieve it. Similarly, lucky people assume social risks more easily (asking for help, introducing themselves to someone, offering their ideas), because they start from the expectation that they will be well received or that “life will be full of good things.” Conversely, those who anticipate negative results tend toward inaction or self-sabotage, thus confirming their bad luck. A simple example: an optimistic person will ask for that promotion at work believing they have good chances, while a pessimistic person won’t even try for fear of rejection; consequently, only the optimist has a chance of “getting lucky” by obtaining it.

Research cited by Wiseman supports that a slight optimism bias can be beneficial even if it implies a certain positive “illusion.” For example, later studies showed that the use of lucky charms or rituals can improve performance by boosting the person’s confidence (positive placebo effect). In one experiment, people with their charm had better results in memory and skill tests than those who had none. Similarly, wishing someone “good luck” before a task improves their execution, and moderate overconfidence can increase productivity and teamwork. Wiseman notes that, while pessimists sometimes see the world more “accurately,” optimists get more luck because their beliefs drive them to act and persist. He calls this “positive superstitions”: beliefs that are not entirely rational but, nevertheless, motivate beneficial behaviors. In summary, expecting the best from life tends to produce better results, whether because one tries harder, because one infects others with enthusiasm, or simply because one is more attentive to opportunities. However, Wiseman warns that optimism should not blind us: it is not about denying reality, but about maintaining hope and a proactive attitude even in difficult times.

4. Transform Bad Luck into Good The Fourth Principle discovered by Wiseman is that lucky people know how to face and convert bad fortune into something positive. Throughout his studies, he noted that even the luckiest individuals face inevitable setbacks; the difference is how they respond to them. “Lucky” people put into practice several psychological strategies when something bad happens: they look for the bright side of what occurred, do not obsess

over the misfortune, and take control of the situation to improve it. This resilient mindset allows them, in many cases, to emerge strengthened from adversity or even use it to their advantage. Wiseman found, for example, that lucky people usually imagine how things could have been worse, which makes them value that “within the bad, they were lucky.” They are also convinced that a stroke of bad luck today can lead to good luck tomorrow (for example, a failed relationship or job might open the path to something better later on). This belief helps them maintain calm and hope after a setback. Furthermore, lucky people avoid pitying themselves eternally: they express their frustration or sadness briefly, but do not get stuck in lamentation. Instead, they turn the page and focus on solutions: they think about what constructive action they can take to prevent the bad luck from repeating.

Wiseman illustrates this principle with concrete examples. In a mental exercise, he asked participants to imagine being shot during a bank robbery. “Unlucky” people tended to consider themselves victims (“what bad luck to get shot”), while “lucky” people interpreted that they had actually been lucky – it could have been worse! After all, they were still alive. Similarly, a lucky volunteer from his study broke his leg falling down the stairs; when Wiseman asked him if he still believed he was lucky, the man replied enthusiastically yes: in the hospital he had met the nurse who later became his wife, “the best thing that has happened to me.” For him, that accident ended up being a blessing in disguise. This ability to reframe events is characteristic of lucky people. In psychological terms, they resort to “positive counterfactual thinking”: they compare the situation with worse possible scenarios, extract lessons, and trust that something good will come of it. Finally, they act to prevent future misfortunes: if something went wrong, they analyze what is under their control (e.g., improving a skill, taking precautions) and implement it, rather than resigning themselves to “fate.” Thanks to these behaviors, they often manage to reverse a run of bad luck. Wiseman summarizes the principle like this: lucky people face adversity with resilience and creativity, so that they frequently manage to “make lemonade out of the lemons” that life gives them.

Studies and Fundamental Experiments of the *Luck Factor*

Wiseman’s research project on luck (known as the “Luck Project”) was the first extensive scientific study focused on this topic. **Participants:** Through advertisements in newspapers and magazines, Wiseman recruited more than 400 volunteers who considered themselves consistently lucky or unlucky in life. This group included people of very varied profiles (students, housewives, business owners, etc.), from 18 to 84 years of age. **Methodology:** Over ~10 years, Wiseman applied multiple methods to obtain objective and subjective data. He conducted detailed interviews with each participant about their life history, attitudes, and beliefs regarding luck. He asked them to keep diaries where they noted lucky or unlucky incidents that happened to them, to analyze patterns. He administered personality questionnaires and psychological scales: he found, for example, that unlucky people scored significantly higher in neuroticism (anxiety) than lucky people. This trait difference is associated with attentive vs. relaxed concentration: anxiety tends to “shrink” the attentional focus, making the person overlook stimuli unrelated to their immediate goal. Wiseman verified this effect in the laboratory with ingenious experiments. In one of them, he asked participants to stare at a dot on a computer screen;

occasionally, large dots appeared unexpectedly on the periphery of the screen. Without pressure, almost everyone noticed the peripheral dots; but when he offered a monetary reward for concentrating on the central dot (inducing tension), more than a third of the participants did not perceive the large dots flashing on the sides. The more they tried to focus narrowly, the less they saw – analogously to how “unlucky” people obsess over a single purpose and miss opportunities around them.

Among the best-known experiments of Wiseman’s study stands out the aforementioned “newspaper experiment,” designed to measure the ability to observe the unexpected. The huge difference in results (the lucky ones found the message “43 photographs” in seconds, the majority of the unlucky ones never saw it) provided direct evidence that good/bad luck depends in part on the perception and attention of each individual. Another component of the research was the “Luck School,” a longitudinal experiment to verify if it was possible to teach luck. Wiseman invited a group of volunteers – both lucky and unlucky – to participate in a month-long program where they would learn to think and act “like lucky people.” During that month, they were assigned practical exercises based on the four principles (e.g.: socialize more and break routines to generate opportunities, practice techniques to listen to intuition, keep a “luck diary” and affirm positive expectations, and apply strategies of reframing adversities). Participants had to note their experiences daily. After a few weeks, Wiseman compiled the results and the findings were notable: 80% of the participants reported feeling happier, more satisfied with their life, and – most importantly – luckier than before. On average, they estimated that their level of personal luck had increased by more than 40% after applying the techniques. Even many originally “unlucky” people began to consider themselves lucky, and those who already believed themselves lucky reinforced that perception even more. Wiseman points out specific cases of transformation: participants who previously felt stuck achieved elusive goals during that period – one woman found her dream job “by chance”; another man met his ideal partner in fortuitous circumstances – attributing these successes to their new, more open mindset.

These results suggest that changing certain mental habits can objectively “increase luck,” at least in terms of achieving more goals and feeling more satisfied. However, Wiseman also acknowledges that part of the effect may be subjective: by paying attention to lucky events (for example, by keeping a record), perhaps one simply becomes more aware of the good luck that previously went unnoticed. In any case, *The Luck Factor* had interesting implications for psychology: it showed that traits like resilience, optimism, social openness, and intuition have a real impact on the experiences we label as “luck.” His research caught the attention of companies and organizations; Wiseman even extended the project to study why some people seem lucky in business and how to increase good fortune at an organizational level. In summary, his experiments provided a scientific basis for the idea that many supposedly fortuitous events are influenced by how we think and act.

Practical Implications: How to Increase Personal Luck?

The practical goal of *The Luck Factor* is to offer anyone tools to improve their own luck by applying the discovered principles. Wiseman argues that luck is not an innate mystical quality,

but a set of habits that can be learned. Some concrete recommendations that arise from his book and experiments are:

- **Cultivate a network of contacts and experiences:** To “maximize your opportunities,” seek to expand your social circle and get out of the routine. For example, set a goal to meet new people: start casual conversations with strangers who inspire confidence (in a line, event, etc.) or reconnect with old acquaintances. Each interaction is a seed of possible opportunity. Likewise, break the routine periodically: try activities you have never done or visit different places. Wiseman even suggests a “dice game” to force yourself into new experiences: make a numbered list from 1 to 6 with things you would like to try (from trying exotic food to learning a new hobby), roll a die every so often, and perform the activity of the number rolled. These practices expand your exposure to the unexpected. Equally, try to maintain a relaxed and attentive attitude in your day-to-day; for example, dedicate moments to walk or observe your surroundings without rushing – you may notice opportunities that go unnoticed if you live in a hurry or stressed. Remember: if you always do the same thing, you will get the same results; luck favors those who create the conditions for something different to occur.
- **Listen to and fine-tune intuition:** To make better “lucky” decisions, it is important to pay attention to your hunches. Practice techniques that help you hear your inner voice. For example, when you must decide something important, take a few minutes of calm to clear your mind; you can try simple meditation (focusing on breathing or repeating a positive word) to reduce mental noise. Then, evaluate what your instinct feels about each option. Wiseman also advises putting intuition to the test: if you have a feeling about something, act according to it on a small scale and observe the result, thus you will learn to calibrate when your intuition is correct. Another strategy is to keep an “intuition diary,” noting hunches and then verifying what happened, to develop a sort of trained sixth sense. Additionally, foster your creativity and imagination – for example, the exercise of visualizing that you consult with an “inner sage” (or your future self) about a problem, articulating aloud what really worries you. These types of dynamics can reveal subconscious desires or fears that pure logic does not show. In summary, trust your instincts a little more (especially in areas where you have experience, since intuition tends to be more reliable there) and do not fear acting when you feel strongly that something is right.
- **Practice optimism and positive expectations:** To attract good luck, expect to have good luck. Deliberately adopt a positive attitude toward your goals. A practical tip is to perform visualizations and affirmations: every morning, dedicate a few minutes to imagining successful scenarios in the projects that matter to you (for example, mentally living yourself having an excellent job interview, giving firm answers, and getting the position). You can also repeat encouraging phrases of the type “Today luck will be on my side” or “Every day I am closer to my goals,” as this helps program your mind into optimistic mode. Another recommendation from Wiseman is to establish concrete short, medium, and long-term goals, write them down, and review your progress regularly. By having clear purposes, you will have more motivation and see related opportunities where others do not (effect of the “reticular activator” in psychology). Likewise, do not let

yourself be discouraged by initial obstacles: if something fails, consider that it is part of the path to success. Remember that “lucky” people usually persevere even when the odds seem low. Cultivating this pragmatic optimism will increase your “grit” and the probability that eventually the balance will tip in your favor. Important: maintain balance – a healthy optimism recognizes reality (it is not about denying problems, but facing them with hope). As Wiseman says, “a little positive self-delusion can be a good thing,” as it reinforces confidence and effort.

- **Develop resilience and a constructive attitude toward bad luck:** Finally, to not let yourself be sunk by bad fortune, practice the techniques of resilient lucky people. When something goes wrong, first of all, avoid magnifying it: try to find the positive side or the lesson. Ask yourself: Could it have been worse? Surely yes – focusing on that will make you feel relief that “it wasn’t that bad.” Then, do not stay stuck in complaint: it is normal to vent after a disappointment (for example, crying or expressing anger with a friend), but put a limit on the lament. After releasing the negative emotion, change activity to clear the mind: exercise, go out with friends, watch a movie, anything that cuts the rumination. This emotional “reset” will allow you to turn the page. Next, adopt a proactive approach: analyze what is under your control to avoid similar future bad luck. Wiseman suggests a process in steps: 1) Instead of thinking “I am a victim,” assume some control of the situation; 2) Take some immediate action, however small, that empowers you (e.g., if you lost your job, sending an application to another company today makes you feel in motion); 3) Brainstorm solutions or consult with trusted people for creative ideas; 4) Draw up a plan with concrete steps and consider the details (times, resources); 5) Put it into action. This constructive approach not only distracts you from misfortune but increases the probability that good luck arises from a bad situation (for example, by actively searching, you might find a better opportunity than the one you lost). In summary, be flexible and optimistic even in adversity: firmly believe that every setback can bring a hidden advantage or a valuable lesson. This resilient mindset is in itself a good luck talisman in the long term.

Applying these principles together, anyone can improve their “luck coefficient” in daily life. In fact, Wiseman’s exercises demonstrated that simply paying more attention to luck (for example, keeping a diary of lucky events) usually increases the perception that good things happen to one. Although we cannot completely control random events, we can control our reaction and preparation for them. As Wiseman concludes, believing in one’s own good luck and acting accordingly can become a positive self-fulfilling prophecy. In colloquial words: “put a charm in your pocket – science says that having faith in your luck could be the key to a better life.”

Criticisms and Debates After the Publication of *The Luck Factor*

Since its appearance in 2003, *The Luck Factor* has generated both enthusiasm and skepticism in the psychological community and the general public. On the positive side, Wiseman’s work is considered pioneering for providing evidence that certain attitudinal traits (optimism, resilience, openness) impact tangible results. His empowering message – that people “can create their

own luck” – has been well received in fields like positive psychology and personal development. However, relevant criticisms and debates have also arisen:

- **New principles or old wisdom?** Some psychologists have pointed out that Wiseman’s four principles closely resemble traditional advice on positive thinking, only reframed under the label of “luck.” For example, having an open attitude, trusting oneself, being optimistic, and overcoming failure are classic recommendations for success. Professor David Aldous commented critically: “If one wanted to write a book on how a positive attitude leads to success, one would arrive at a list of very similar maxims, only normally we wouldn’t mention the word luck.” In this sense, they suggest that Wiseman may have performed a rebranding of already known principles, leveraging the hook of the concept of “luck” to present them. Wiseman responds that, while there is overlap with common sense ideas, his contribution was to scientifically demonstrate the connection between those habits and perceived luck, in addition to offering a unified framework and practical exercises to develop them.
- **Sample and confirmation bias:** Another criticism focuses on the methodology. Wiseman selected subjects who already thought in terms of luck (they called themselves very lucky or very unlucky). This could introduce a self-selection bias: possibly these people had peculiarities that did not represent everyone. Furthermore, once in the study, they were made to keep diaries and focus on their luck, which could activate a confirmation bias. Writer Karla Starr notes that if you tell someone to perform actions to increase their luck and note their strokes of luck, it is very likely that they will start noticing more lucky events than before simply by being more attentive. That is, perhaps it is not that “objectively” more good things happen to them, but that they perceive/report them more. This phenomenon (also known as the subject expectancy effect) suggests that part of the success of the Luck School could be due to the participants, believing they were doing something to be luckier, interpreting more daily events as “luck.” Starr notes that Wiseman did not explicitly address this possible placebo or expectation effect in the book. If subjects simply feel luckier, it is worth asking if their real luck changed or only their perception. Wiseman might reply that, even if it were “only psychological,” feeling lucky is not trivial: it is linked to greater well-being, confidence, and openness, which in the long run can generate positive real results. All in all, this criticism invites qualifying the conclusions: perhaps Wiseman’s method works largely because it changes the attitude rather than chance itself, something the author himself partly acknowledges.
- **Role of external factors and unfairness of chance:** Some commentators have highlighted that, while the proposal to “become lucky” is motivating, not all luck in life is under personal control. Aspects such as place of birth, socioeconomic context, health, privileges, or structural disadvantages are “lotteries” that hugely affect the opportunities of each individual. One article pointed out that this “invisible luck” (external circumstances) can give the false impression that only individual effort matters, ignoring starting inequalities. From this perspective, it is warned that one should not blame those who suffer systemic bad luck by telling them it is for not thinking positively. Wiseman in his book does not deny the influence of pure chance or external factors (in fact, he

mentions that some events really escape our control); his focus centers on what we *can* improve. Even so, critics suggest complementing the discussion of luck with awareness of those limits: adopting a good attitude increases the chances of success, but does not guarantee equitable results for all. The debate here revolves around balancing personal responsibility and randomness/structure: *The Luck Factor* leans toward the former, while others recall the weight of the latter.

- **Additional empirical evidence:** After Wiseman, there has been research supporting or refining his ideas. Studies in social psychology have confirmed, for example, that exaggerated optimism can improve performance (Pygmalion effect) and that resilience is associated with better results after adverse events. On the other hand, the notion of “intuitive trust” has been nuanced: intuition is usually useful in areas where one has experience, but can fail in unknown terrains. No direct refutation of Wiseman’s findings has been reported, as far as is known, although the nature of “luck” continues to be debated. Is luck simply a cognitive construction (selective perception) or does it also imply objective components? Wiseman would argue that it is both: lucky and unlucky people live different experiences over time precisely because of their behavioral differences. In any case, *The Luck Factor* opened an interesting line of dialogue between psychology and the popular notion of luck, inspiring other authors to explore the topic in areas like business, sports, or relationships.

In conclusion, *The Luck Factor* by Richard Wiseman presents an optimistic and data-based look at a traditionally mysterious concept. His main contributions are demonstrating that many “strokes of luck” are not mere coincidence, but depend in part on how we think and act, and that these lucky behaviors can be learned and cultivated. For individuals and organizations, the practical implications are valuable: fostering curiosity, connection with others, listening to intuition, realistic optimism, and resilience can translate into more seized opportunities and a life with greater satisfactions. While it is important to recognize the limits imposed by genuine chance, Wiseman’s work invites us to empower ourselves: adopting the four principles of luck amounts to “stacking the cards in our favor” in the great game of life. As a review summarizes, “Wiseman shows us that luck, in large measure, is the result of our perspective. We do not control everything that happens, but we do control the best way to react when an opportunity arises.” Ultimately, *The Luck Factor* teaches us that luck can be improved, and that sometimes the first step to having more luck is believing it and acting accordingly.

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